...THE PUDDING...

...STRIKES BACK...

IMPORTANT INFORMATION

OBJECTIVE

Your mission is to defend Santa Claus and his friends against the evil Christmas pudding and other foes that are attacking Santa's home planet. So, get into your X-Wing and engage your engines for Santa's rescue!



RUNNING THE GAME

The game runs directly from 5.25” floppy. After booting and loading all necessary modules there is only disk access at the end of the game when you press **Q** for **QUIT** from the game when the current high score is written back to the disk. If you don’t leave the game properly via quit the current high score will not be saved to disk!

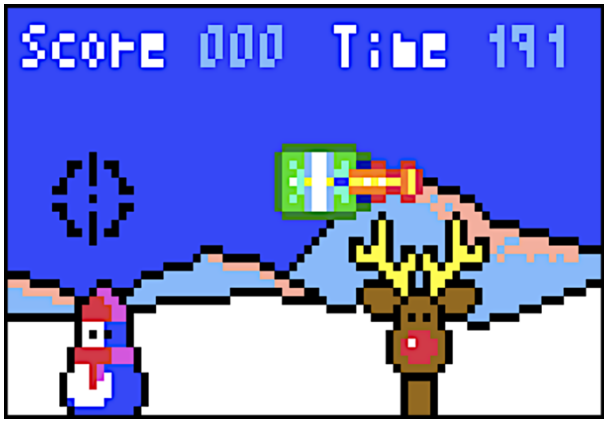
SYSTEM REQUIREMENTS

- Apple //e, //c, //c+ or IIgs
    - Apple IIgs might need setting **Alternate Display Mode** to **ON**!
- **Required**: 65C02 CPU, 128k RAM, Joystick
- **Optional**: MockingBoard
    - **Auto-activation** for a MockingBoard 4c (Apple //c, //c+) has been added to the game. You can directly boot the game and listen to the soundtrack without prior manual activation of the MockingBoard.
- After booting the disk there will be **no system test** performed! Hence if you use the game on a system out of spec the game will crash during booting.

GAMEPLAY AND STRATEGY

- **Objective:** Shoot down the incoming enemy foes with your laser gun until the timer runs out! The timer is set to fixed 200 time units which are about 200 seconds of play time depending on having a MockingBoard installed or not. Without a MockingBoard

the game runs slightly faster. See the technical tidbit section below for more information on that special behavior .



- **Enemies:** five different enemies at varying trajectories with different velocities yielding score points depending on the **difficulty** to shoot them down!
    - **Candy cane:** easiest to shoot down being the slowest enemy (3 or 5 points).
    - **Christmas pudding:** medium difficulty (4 or 6 points).
    - **Gingerbread man:** more difficult to shoot down (5 or 7 points).
    - **Turkey:** fastest enemy with a high difficulty (8 or 10 points).
    - **Champagne bottle:** hardest enemy to shoot down, accelerates horizontally in both directions with fast movement changes (20 points).

- **Strategy:** There are different approaches trying to get the highest scores.
    - Some people like to **focus on champagne bottles** and camp somewhere at the screen's left or right edges with the crosshair in order to get the fast moving bottles in time. However, you **cannot predict** which direction the next bottle will fly so this also depends large parts on personal luck.
    - It is possible to **follow** the champagne bottle as it flies out of the screen if you initially miss it. The bottle **can be outrun** since it slows down before it finally disappears from the screen, but it is hard to do and needs some training!
    - Some people like to **camp in the screen center** and wait for objects to come like passing by fast turkeys.
    - However, another concept would be staying in the **lower parts of the screen** with the crosshair trying to catch the flying objects.
    - Whatever you decide, we wish you good luck and good aiming!

- **CAUTION: each shot costs one point!** So be careful not wasting your ammo and to shoot only when you are definitely on target!

JOYSTICK AND KEYBOARD COMMANDS

- **PDL 0/1**: Controls the aiming crosshair.
- **Button #0**: Fire button – but **be careful**: each shot costs you **one** point!
- **Q**: quit the game and the high score will be saved to disk. If you quit the game **without** pressing key **Q** the high score will **not** be saved!
- **R**: press key **R** any time to reset the score and restart the timer. This also restarts the game when the *GAME OVER*-message is displayed.
- **T**: if you need to pause the game for a while press key **T** but be careful this is **not safe for work**!

KNOWN LIMITATIONS



The game runs nicely on original hardware in standard configurations as well as in emulators. A **65C02** and **128k RAM** is a must, **MockingBoard** is optional and needed for the soundtrack.

Problems have been reported when using a **FastChip** on an Apple //e which can lead to a system crash or hanging game when the background music is playing. Be sure to switch the FastChip to **normal mode** using the white switch when playing the game.

You can play the game without problems using a **TWGS** on a IIgs (and a CFFA3000).

Problems with **floppy emus** have not yet been reported. However, we suggest you play the game on a standard system with disk drive for best experience.

Even though there are some keyboard commands in the game engine the menu system requires a **joystick** for interaction. **Keyboard control** of the crosshair is **not available** and will never be. There is **no mouse support**.

If you only have **monochrome video** the game play experience is limited. We suggest playing the game on a color monitor.

Restarting the game with MockingBoard installed needs a power cycle to make the game work properly. The reason for that is yet unknown. Without MockingBoard the game can be restarted without any cold or warm boot.

Some **sprites flicker** when traversing the screen. This is caused by limitations of the DOLORES sprite engine.

If you run into any **problems** when playing the game with issues that are **not** reported here, please let me know: bugs@8bitshack.org

TECHNICAL TIDBITS

- The **DOLORES library** and the **PT3-player** module reside directly below the DOS 3.3 area. DOLORES was adapted for this game by removing unused functions in order to make the code more compact and faster.
- **PT3** is a file format of modules produced by **Pro Tracker v3.xx** for the ZX Spectrum which can be played back on the Apple II thanks to a **PT3-library** produced by Deater of VMW-Software.
- Half of the **zero page** is used for DOLORES and PT3-player variables. The zero page is saved during the algorithm startup and restored when leaving the game which keeps the Apple in "normal" working state afterwards. Maybe not necessarily needed - I like this feature of a clean quit from the game algorithm.
- The **song data** is loaded at **$2000** occupying 2kB of space (PT3-file / Vortex-Tracker).

- **AUX memory** is used by the DOLORES library and the game: the machine code is copied to AUX RAM. When doing the background scrolling program execution temporarily switches to AUX memory.
- The **interrupt handler** controlling the sound file playback got an extra **JSR** to a routine that will manage things that need timed action during the gameplay and enhance "random" game behavior. However, the game will run fine without a MockingBoard.



- The **PT3 player** uses about 15% of the CPU cycles when playing music files, hence the game will run slightly faster when no MockingBoard is installed.

MORE INFORMATION

Visit the website http://pudding.golombeck.eu to get more information about the game and find the latest **free downloadable** DSK-image for your floppy emu or emulator!

